

village for Standards 8 and 9. Later, recognising his academic potential, his father, who had studied only up to the third standard but strongly believed in education, sent him to Rajkot for higher-secondary studies. There, Ganesh studied at Shri Saurashtra High School, living in a rented room with two other students from nearby villages.

Ganesh performed strongly academically, securing first rank at the Rajkot centre in his Class 12 board examinations.

“At that time, Gujarat had only a handful of engineering colleges and admissions were based solely on board examination results, as entrance tests did not exist,” shares Ganesh.

Initially, he secured admission to a medical college in Ahmedabad. However, during his visit there, he learned about a newly introduced computer science engineering course at The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda. Encouraged by a senior who believed the field had a promising future, Ganesh made a bold decision to switch paths. Without prior exposure to computers, he dropped the medical admission and enrolled in the BE computer science programme at the university’s Faculty of Technology and Engineering in Vadodara.

“In those days, higher education in government colleges was highly affordable, as private engineering and medical colleges were virtually non-existent,” says Ganesh.

Although his family’s financial situation was modest, Ganesh’s academic performance earned him a national scholarship, which provided monthly financial assistance from the government. This support, combined with his father’s determination to educate him, enabled him to pursue higher studies and build the future he envisioned.

Early learning and self-reliance

Ganesh eventually enrolled in engineering. Although higher education



Ganesh Jivani (Centre) with his college friends during engineering days

was relatively affordable at the time, it still involved certain expenses, which he chose to manage on his own. During his engineering years, he took up a few tuitions to support himself. In total, he taught four students, most of whom were preparing for the SSC examinations, while one required special assistance in mathematics.

Recalling those days, Ganesh explains that he taught a young woman in Vadodara who was preparing for competitive examinations such as the UPSC and GPSC, where analytical and aptitude tests were important components. As engineering students were generally strong in analytical thinking, Ganesh helped her prepare for those sections. In addition, he guided a school student interested in basic computer programming. Although the number of tuitions was small, the experience was memorable and meaningful for him.

Although Ganesh excelled academically, he had little interest in sports. He recalls that during those days, there was a common belief that students who were serious about their studies should focus only on academics. It was widely assumed that one could be either academically strong or actively

participate in sports, but not both. As a result, Ganesh stayed away from sports and instead developed a strong interest in reading. Over time, reading became one of his favourite pastimes, a habit he continues to cherish whenever he finds the time.

His reading preferences leaned more towards fiction and autobiographies. Ganesh believes learning does not necessarily come only from management or academic books. Valuable lessons, he says, can be drawn from a wide range of reading material, whether fiction, autobiographies, or even newspapers. For him, every book offers insights and perspectives that contribute to personal growth.

Learning beyond engineering

Having studied in Gujarati-medium schools until Class 12, he had to adapt quickly when engineering instruction shifted to English. The transition was challenging. All his scientific and mathematical concepts had been learned in Gujarati, and suddenly he had to understand and communicate them in English.

The language barrier became especially evident during his first year at the Faculty of Technology and Engineering in Vadodara.